small auditorium of the RBI in Bombay, E. Gerald Corrigan, President of the New York Federal Reserve Bank was delivering the C.D. Deshmukh Memorial Lecture in January 1990. The auditorium was full to overflowing and the RBI officials who had organised the event were in a contretemps as Mrs Corrigan was without a seat. Since it would have been rude to single out any of those occupying the front rows to surrender a seat, the fact that Mrs Corrigan was without a seat was whispered loudly enough for all to hear. Parekh, who was sitting in the front row, though old and feeble, jumped up with great alacrity and offered his seat to Mrs Corrigan. None of the other dignitaries in the front row bothered to move!

A man of tireless energy and an incurable optimism for the future of the country, Parekh was no less a visionary in other fields as well. Many years before the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) was established, he had recommended such a watchdog body for the stock market. He also advocated a Common Asian Market, being a great admirer of Jean Monnet, one of the chief architects of the European Common Market. In keeping with his zeal for establishing new ventures, in 1983, Parekh promoted the first private sector oil exploration company in India, Hindustan Oil exploration Company Limited. He also set up Gujarat Rural Housing Finance Corporation Limited in 1986, an institution for providing rural housing finance in villages and small towns.

Parekh was a writer with a prolific output. In addition to being a regular contributor to the media with over 200 published articles to his credit on a variety of subjects such as industry, economic policy, capital market, and development banking, he was the author of several books. All his writings are remarkable for their clarity, vision, and incisive comments on the issues of finance and economics. He wrote *The Bombay Money Market*, a book which detailed the intricate workings of the money market in India. He also wrote about his experience as a development banker in *The Story of a Development Bank: ICICI 1955–1979*. Also, his writings in Gujarati, *Hirane Patro* (letters to his wife Hira) and *Hirane Vadhu Patro*, (letters to his wife Hira after her demise), find a place of importance in Gujarati literature. As Parekh himself observed, ‘I seem to enjoy sitting at the feet of Saraswati more than worshipping Laxmi, though it is Laxmi I have served all my life.’[10]